Laís Lautenschlager Rodrigues, Ph.D.

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Portuguese – Fluent, Native
English – Fluent
Spanish - Beginner

My name is Laís, and I am a Brazilian field ecologist specializing in tropical forest ecosystems and plant-animal interactions. In 2025, I earned a Ph.D. in Biology from the University of Miami, where I enhanced my skills in fieldwork, geospatial analysis, molecular techniques (e-DNA), and statistical analysis. During my academic career, I had the opportunity to work with medium- and large-sized animal species and their ecological roles in tropical rainforests, particularly examining the anthropogenic impacts on species diversity, and conservation challenges across Neotropical landscapes.

Over the years, I have published 14 peer-reviewed articles, three of which were as first author, in leading journals, including *Biological Conservation*, *PNAS*, and *Ecology*. In addition to research, I have been a leading instructor and teaching assistant since 2023 in several undergraduate and graduate courses at the University of Miami and São Paulo State University. I am fluent in Portuguese and English, with research experience spanning Brazil, the United States, Colombia, and Uruguay.

University of Miami (UM), Department of Biology, Miami, FL, USA **2020 – 2025**

Doctor in Philosophy (Ph.D.) degree in Biology
Project**:** "*Dietary Ecological Functioning of a Large Herbivore in a Tropical Forest*"

São Paulo State University (UNESP), Department of Ecology, Rio Claro, SP, Brazil **2017 – 2019**
Master of Science (MS) degree in Ecology and Biodiversity
Project: "*Effects of Domestic Livestock and Landscape on the Diversity of Mammals in the Atlantic Forest Remnants*"

São Paulo State University (UNESP), Department of Ecology, Rio Claro, SP, Brazil **2012 – 2016**
Bachelor of Science (BS) degree in Ecology
Project: "*Frugivory and Seed Dispersal by the Red-footed Tortoise (Chelonoidis carbonaria*)"

- PUBLICATIONS

Regolin, A. L., Collevatti, R. G., Bailey, L. L., Boscolo, D., **Lautenschlager, L**., Beca, G., Dias, V. B., Galetti, M. (**2025**). Habitat fragmentation explains the occupancy probability of the largest herbivore in the Neotropical forests. *Biological Conservation*, 311, 111413. 10.1016/j.biocon.2025.111413

Fortier, R. P., Kullberg, A. T., Aragón, L., Bernal-Escobar, M., Contreras, M. P., Hurtado, C. P., **Lautenschlager, L.**, Feeley, K. J. (**2025**). Plant Diversity and Endemism of the Sierra Nevada De Santa Marta, Colombia, with Floristic Comparisons to Surrounding Mountains1. *Annals of the Missouri Botanical Garden*, 110(1), 71-87. 10.3417/2025921

Kullberg, A. T., Aragón, L., Bernal-Escobar, M., Fortier, R., **Lautenschlager, L.**, Ballantyne, J., & Feeley, K.J. (**2024**). Rising temperatures will make Miami's street life even more exotic. *Urban Forestry & Urban Greening*, 128502. 10.1016/j.ufug.2024.128502

Kim, S., **Lautenschlager, L.**, Tarazona-Tubens, F. L., Abels, J., Lloret, M., Park, T., Malcolm-Parker, A., Galetti, M., Searcy, C. (**2024**). Resurrecting plant–animal interactions in the Caribbean can benefit large-fruited plants. *Restoration Ecology*, e14233. 10.1111/rec.14233.

Gonçalves, F., Farooq, H., Harfoot, M., Pires, M. M., Villar, N., Sales, L., Carvalho, C., Bello, C., Emer, C., Bovendorp, R. S., Mendes, C., Beca, G., **Lautenschlager, L**., Souza, Y., Pedrosa, F., … Galetti, M. (**2024**). A global map of species at risk of extinction due to natural hazards. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, *121*(26), e2321068121. 10.1073/pnas.2321068121.

Lautenschlager, L., Souza, Y., Villar, N., Galetti, M., & Feeley, K. J. (**2024**). Communal tapir latrines are foraging sites for tropical forest vertebrates. *Global Ecology and Conservation*, e02950. 10.1016/j.gecco.2024.e02950.

Lautenschlager, L. & Feeley, K. (**2024**). Poop is cool! Animal latrines help animals and plants. *Frontiers for Young Minds journal.* 12, 1284583. 10.3389/frym.2024.1284583.

Franceschi, I. C., da Paixão Dornas, R. A., Lermen, I. S., Coelho, A. V. P., Boas, A. H. V., Chiarello, A. G., et al. (**2024**). Camera trap surveys of Atlantic Forest mammals: A data set for analyses considering imperfect detection (2004-2020). *Ecology*, e4298. 10.1002/ecy.4298

Lautenschlager, L., Souza, Y., & Galetti, M. (**2022**). Frugivory and seed dispersal by the Red-footed Tortoise *Chelonoidis carbonaria*. *Acta Oecologica*, 116, 103837. 10.1016/j.actao.2022.103837.

Galetti, M., Gonçalves, F., Villar, N., Zipparro, V. B., Paz, C., Mendes, C., **Lautenschlager, L**., … Bovendorp, R. S. (**2021**). Causes and consequences of large-scale defaunation in the Atlantic Forest. In M. C. M. Marques & C. E. V. Grelle (Eds.), The Atlantic Forest. History, biodivesity, threats and opportunities of the mega-diverse forest (pp. 297-324). 10.1007/978-3-030-55322-7_14.

Mendes, C. P., Carreira, D., Pedrosa, F., Beca, G., **Lautenschlager, L**., Akkawi, P., ... & Galetti, M. (**2020**). Landscape of human fear in Neotropical rainforest mammals. *Biological Conservation*, 241, 108257. 10.1016/j.biocon.2019.108257.

Nagy-Reis, M., Oshima, J. E. D. F., Kanda, C. Z., Palmeira, F. B. L., de Melo, F. R., Morato, R. G., ... & Lopes, C. M. (**2020**). NEOTROPICAL CARNIVORES: a data set on carnivore distribution in the Neotropics. *Ecology*, 101(11), e03128. 10.1002/ecy.3128.

Souza, Y., Gonçalves, F., **Lautenschlager, L**., Akkawi, P., Mendes, C., Carvalho, M. M., ... & Galetti, M. (**2019**). ATLANTIC MAMMALS: a data set of assemblages of medium-and large-sized mammals of the Atlantic Forest of South America. *Ecology*, 100(10), e02785. 10.1002/ecy.2785.

Sobral-Souza, T., **Lautenschlager, L**., Morcatty, T. Q., Bello, C., Hansen, D., & Galetti, M. (**2017**). Rewilding defaunated Atlantic Forests with tortoises to restore lost seed dispersal functions. *Perspectives in ecology and conservation*, 15(4), 300-307. 10.1016/j.pecon.2017.08.005.

- ***Publications*** *– under review*

Lautenschlager, et al. (**July 2025**). *NeoUngulates*: A Database of Ungulate Diets in the Neotropics. *Ecology*.

Lautenschlager, et al. (**November 2025**). Unveiling the dietary selection of Lowland tapirs (*Tapirus terrestris*) in a tropical rainforest. *Ecology and Evolution*.

- COMPLEMENTARY EDUCATION

Geospatial Technology – Certificate obtained by the Department of Geography, University of Miami **2025**
Geographic Information Systems (GIS) and satellite Remote Sensing – ArcGIS Pro software

R-Ladies Belo Horizonte – Online Course, Belo Horizonte, MG, Brazil **2022**
Short-term course in Data Analysis with Tidyverse – R software

Florestal Package – Online Course, São Paulo, Brazil **2021**
Short-term course in Introduction of Geospatial Data – R software

Federal University of Rio Grande do Sul (UFRGS), Porto Alegre, RS, Brazil **2019**
Short-term course in Introduction to Hierarchical Models in Ecology – R software

São Paulo State University (UNESP), Rio Claro, SP, Brazil **2019**
Short-term course in Introduction of R: data management, visualization, and analysis – R software

Geoprocessing without borders, Rio de Janeiro, RJ, Brazil **2017**
Short-term course about GIS in the analysis of environmental risks – ArcGIS Desktop software

São Paulo State University (UNESP), Rio Claro, SP, Brazil **2016**
Short-term course in *Scientific Photography*

São Paulo State University (UNESP), Rio Claro, SP, Brazil **2015**
Short-term course in *Ornithology Studies*

São Paulo State University (UNESP), Rio Claro, SP, Brazil **2014**
Short-term course in *Herpetology Studies*

São Paulo State University (UNESP), Rio Claro, SP, Brazil **2014**
Short-term course in *Ecology and Seed Dispersal of Bats*

São Paulo State University (UNESP), Rio Claro, SP, Brazil **2012**
Short-term course in *Introduction to Bird Ecology*

- EXPERIENCES

- **Teaching Experiences**

Course: *General Biology Laboratory (BIL 151)* **Fall 2025**
Instructor Dr. Dana Krempels
Teaching Assistant (TA) Fellow from the Department of Biology
University of Miami, Coral Gables, Florida, USA

Course: *Evolution and Biodiversity (BIL 160)* **Spring 2025**
Instructor Dr. Kenneth J. Feeley
Teaching Assistant (TA) Fellow from the Department of Biology
University of Miami, Coral Gables, Florida, USA

Course: *Workshop Leaders in Biology II (BIL 382)* **Spring 2025**
Instructor Dr. Kenneth J. Feeley
Teaching Assistant (TA) Fellow from the Department of Biology
University of Miami, Coral Gables, Florida, USA

Course: *General Biology Laboratory (BIL 151)* **Fall 2024**
Instructor Dr. Dana Krempels
Teaching Assistant (TA) Fellow from the Department of Biology
University of Miami, Coral Gables, Florida, USA

Course: *Ecology (BIL 336)* **Fall 2024**
Instructor Dr. Michelle E. Afkhami
Teaching Assistant (TA) Fellow from the Department of Biology
University of Miami, Coral Gables, Florida, USA

Course: *Introduction to Latin American and Caribbean Studies (LAS101-Q)* **Fall 2023**
Instructor Dr. John Twichell
Teaching Assistant (TA) Fellow from the UMIA - Institute for Advanced Study of the Americas
University of Miami, Coral Gables, Florida, USA

Course: *Fieldwork Ecology* **2015, 2018**
Instructor Dr. Mauro Galetti
Teaching Assistant (TA) from the Department of Ecology and Biodiversity
São Paulo State University, campus Rio Claro, São Paulo, Brazil

- **Events - Organization Committee**

22nd Tri-University Latin America and Caribbean Studies Graduate Student Conference **2024**
(UM, FIU, FAU) – University of Miami, Coral Gables, Florida, USA

10th Brazilian Congress of Mastozoology, Águas de Lindóia, SP, Brazil **2019**

3rd Workshop of Ecosystem Services, São Paulo State University, Rio Claro, SP, Brazil **2015**

- **Presentation in Events**

2nd Defaunation Workshop, Center for Research on Biodiversity Dynamics and Climate Change **2025**
Oral presentation: "-"

6th Annual Distinguished Fellows Colloquium, Institute for Advanced Study of the Americas (UMIA) **2024**
Oral presentation: "Dietary Ecological Roles of Lowland Tapirs in a Tropical Forest"

8th Frugivores & Seed Dispersal Symposium (FSD), Ilhéus, Bahia, Brazil **2024**
Oral presentation: "Communal tapir latrines are foraging sites for tropical forest vertebrates"

8th Frugivores & Seed Dispersal Symposium (FSD), Ilhéus, Bahia, Brazil **2024**
Oral presentation: "Unveiling the dietary selection of the Lowland tapir (*Tapirus terrestris*) in a tropical forest"
Symposia: "Harnessing nucleic acids to unveil the ecology and evolution of frugivory and seed dispersal"

15th Annual Graduate Student Symposium, 15th Annual Graduate Student Symposium **2024**
Oral presentation: "Communal tapir latrines are foraging sites for tropical forest vertebrates"

13th International Mammalogical Congress (IMC-13), Anchorage, Alaska, USA **2023**
Oral presentation: "Lowland Tapir latrines as an alternative food source for vertebrates in the Atlantic Forest"

14th Annual Graduate Student Symposium, Department of Biology, University of Miami **2023**
Poster presentation: "Lowland Tapir latrines as an alternative food source for vertebrates in the Atlantic Forest"

Friday Seminar – Biology Graduate Program, Department of Biology, University of Miami **2021**
Oral presentation: "Dietary ecological functioning of ungulates in a tropical forest"

12th Annual Graduate Student Symposium, Department of Biology, University of Miami **2021**
Poster presentation: "Biogeography of mutualistic interactions in island ecosystems"

10th Brazilian Congress of Mastozoology, Águas de Lindóia, SP, Brazil **2019**
Oral presentation: "Effects of domestic megafauna and landscape on the diversity of mammals in the Atlantic Forest remnants"

6th Theoretical Ecology Symposium, University of Campinas (UNICAMP), Campinas, SP, Brazil **2018**
Poster presentation: "Frugivory and Seed Dispersal by the Red-footed Tortoise (*Chelonoidis carbonaria*)"

- **Community Outreach Initiatives**

BioReach – Department of Biology Outreach program – University of Miami **2023**

Volunteer to teach students about biological concepts in the Ponce de León Middle School, Miami, FL, USA

Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) – United Nations, Rio Claro, SP, Brazil **2019**

Volunteer during the event "Knowing the 17 Sustainable Development Goals of the United Nations"

Academic Preparation Course– ATHO, São Paulo State University, Rio Claro, SP, Brazil **2011- 2015**

Contributing to the integration of underprivileged communities through a preparatory course at São Paulo State University, focusing on equipping young adults and adults for admission to Brazilian public universities. Responsibilities included teaching English classes, organizing educational events, and actively participating as a member of the organizing committee.

- **Non-Governmental Organization Internship**

Karumbé – Centro de Tortugas Marinas, La Coronilla, Uruguay **2014**

Collaborated with the NGO "Karumbé" in sea turtle research and conservation within Cerro Verde's protected marine area, Uruguay. Activities included beach monitoring, animal sightings, capturing, tagging, rehabilitating marine animals, and overseeing their release.

- **Fieldwork Assistant**

Michaela Peterson (Ph.D., Vanderbilt University, USA) **2019**
Monitoring white-lipped peccaries with camera trapping and following tracks in Brazil.

Vincent Fehr (Ph.D., Aarhus University, Denmark) **2018**
Studying exotic palms and their potential for invasion in the Atlantic Forest in Brazil.

Thomas Arkwright (MSc., University of Copenhagen, Denmark) **2017**
Studying the maned-wolf population in a savanna (protected area) in Brazil.

- EXTERNAL FUNDINGS

- ***Grants and Awards***

Dean's Summer Research Fellowship – University of Miami
Title: "Nutrient Fertilization and Plant Recruitment by the Lowland tapir (*Tapirus terrestris*)"
Period: Summer 2024
Amount: USD 5,000 Status: Funded

Summer Doctoral Research Grant – Graduate School – University of Miami
Title: "Nutrient Fertilization and Plant Recruitment by the Lowland tapir (*T. terrestris*) in a Tropical Forest"
Period: Summer 2024
Amount: USD 5,000 Status: Funded

Kushlan Graduate Research Support Award – Department of Biology, University of Miami
Title: "Nutrient fertilization and plant recruitment by the Lowland tapir (*Tapirus terrestris*)"
Period: Summer 2024
Amount: USD 800.00 Status: Funded

Lewis and Clark Fund for Exploration and Field Research
Title: "Dietary Ecological Functioning of Large Mammalian Herbivores in a Tropical Forest"
Period: Summer 2023
Amount: USD 4,900 Status: Funded

Latin American Student Field Research Award (American Society of Mammalogists – ASM)
Title: "Dietary Ecological Functioning of Large Mammalian Herbivores in a Tropical Forest"
Period: Summer 2023
Amount: USD 1,500 Status: Funded

Kushlan Graduate Research Support Award – Department of Biology, University of Miami
Title: "Comparing Dietary Ecological Functions of Herbivores in a Tropical Forest"
Period: Summer 2023
Amount: USD 500.00 Status: Funded

CNPq - Brazilian National Council for Scientific and Technological Development (process #405839/2021-9)
Title: "Defaunation Effects on the Ecological Functions of Plant Communities in Tropical Forests"
PI: Dr. Mauro Galetti
Period: 2021 – 2022
Amount: R$ 82,500 (USD 16,500 approx.) Status: Funded

- *Fellowships*

UMIA/LAS Distinguished Graduate Fellows Program (Ph.D.)
Project: "Dietary Ecological Functioning of Large Mammalian Herbivores in Tropical Forests"
PI: Dr. Kenneth Feeley (Fall 2022 – Fall 2025)
Period: Academic Year 2023 – 2024
Amount: USD 30,000 Status: Funded

Aldridge Graduate Scholarship in Tropical Biology (Ph.D.)
Project: "Dietary Ecological Functioning of Large Mammalian Herbivores in Tropical Forests"
PI: Dr. Mauro Galetti (Fall 2020 – Spring 2022)
Period: Fall 2021 – Spring 2023
Amount: USD 24,950 Status: Funded

CAPES (Coordination for the Improvement of Higher Education Personnel (M.Sc.)
Project: "Effects of Domestic Livestock and Landscape on the Diversity of Mammals in the Atlantic Forest Remnants"
PI: Dr. Mauro Galetti
Period: 2017 – 2019

CNPQ (National Council for Scientific and Technological Development) (BS)
Project: "Frugivory and Seed Dispersal by the Red-footed Tortoise (*Chelonoidis carbonaria*)"
PI: Dr. Mauro Galetti
Period: 2012 – 2016